

The Desert

There is a place in the spiritual life that no one wants to visit.

It is the desert.

The desert is that season of life when the answers seem to disappear. You pray and feel nothing. You ask and receive nothing. You seek direction and find silence. You look toward the future and cannot see the way forward. What once seemed so clear becomes dark.

It is the place where God seems far away.

And perhaps that is precisely why the desert is so necessary.

We are accustomed to believing that God's presence should be felt through comfort, signs, ease, and answers. When things go well, we say that God is with us. When doors open, we give thanks. When a prayer is answered, our faith grows stronger.

But what happens when nothing goes right?

What happens when God seems silent?

What happens when you keep praying and heaven remains silent?

That is where a different kind of faith begins.

A faith that does not depend on what the eyes can see.

St. Augustine wrote:

“Faith is to believe what you do not see; the reward of this faith is to see what you believe.”

This statement appears in his Sermon 43, in the context of his reflection on faith and perseverance.

Perhaps this is the true test of faith.

To believe when we still cannot see.

To continue when we still do not understand.

To hope when there are still no signs.

Because it is easy to trust in God when everything happens exactly as we would like.

What is difficult is trusting Him when it doesn't.

It is in the desert that we discover whether we truly love God or whether we simply love the benefits we hope to receive from Him.

The Desert Is Not Abandonment

Throughout the Bible, the desert repeatedly appears as a place of testing, purification, and encounter with God.

Israel crossed the desert before reaching the Promised Land.

Moses encountered God in the desert.

Elijah passed through the desert.

John the Baptist lived in the desert.

And Christ Himself was led by the Spirit into the desert.

This should make us stop and think.

If the desert were simply a sign of abandonment, why would so many of the most important stories of Revelation take place precisely there?

Perhaps because the desert strips away the things we normally use to hide our dependence on God.

There is no abundance in the desert.

There are no distractions.

There are no guarantees.

There are not many alternatives.

There is simply you, your need, and God.

And that can be frightening.

We are accustomed to filling every void immediately. If we are sad, we look for entertainment. If we are anxious, we look for information. If we are lonely, we look for someone. If we are frustrated, we look for something to distract us.

Silence makes us uncomfortable.

Waiting makes us uncomfortable.

The absence of answers makes us uncomfortable.

That is why many people never come to know what is truly within them. They are simply too busy to notice.

The desert interrupts all of that.

And when all the distractions disappear, we finally begin to hear what had been hidden.

The Desert humbles Us

One of the strongest sayings attributed to St. Bernadette of Lourdes is:

“Many humiliations are needed to make a little humility.”

The saying is recorded in spiritual works associated with the saint.

It is an uncomfortable statement because it touches on a truth we do not like to admit: often we do not learn humility because we want to learn it. We learn it because life puts us in situations where we discover that we are not as strong, as intelligent, as important, or as indispensable as we imagined.

Humiliation reveals our limits.

And we do not like limits.

We want to control.

We want to anticipate.

We want to choose.

We want to understand.

We want things to happen on our timetable.

But the desert teaches us a word our age has almost forgotten:

dependence.

You do not control everything.

You do not know everything.

You cannot solve everything.

You cannot protect yourself from every circumstance.

And recognizing this is not weakness.

It is the beginning of humility.

Perhaps some of the greatest graces in our lives have arrived disguised as circumstances that wounded our pride.

A door that closed.

An opportunity we lost.

A rejection.

A failure.

Someone who did not recognize our worth.

A plan that did not work.

A prayer that seemed to go unanswered.

At the time, we asked:

“Why?”

Years later, perhaps we discover:

“Thank God.”

Not always.

But sometimes.

And that distinction matters.

We do not have to claim that everything that happens to us is good. Many things truly are bad. Some wounds remain painful. Some losses never stop being losses.

But we can believe that God is capable of acting even in terrain that we would consider completely barren.

The Desert Is Also Silence

Perhaps the hardest part of the desert is not the pain.

It is the silence.

Because we can endure many things when we know there is an explanation.

The problem is when there isn't one.

You ask and receive no answer.

You pray and see no change.

You look for a sign and find nothing but silence.

That is when faith is purified.

Psalm 88 is perhaps one of the most striking expressions of this spiritual state. The psalmist does not hide his anguish. He asks God why He rejects him, speaks of his affliction, and ends by describing the estrangement of his friends and companions.

It is an uncomfortable psalm because it does not end with an easy solution.

And that is profoundly human.

There are moments when prayer is not a celebration.

It is a cry.

“God, where are You?”

“Why don't You answer?”

“How long?”

“Why have You left me alone?”

The Bible is not afraid of these questions.

And that matters.

Because it means faith does not require us to pretend that we are fine.

You can be distressed and still believe.

You can fail to understand and still trust.

You can cry and still pray.

You can feel God's absence and still seek Him.

The absence of a felt sense of God's presence is not necessarily the absence of God.

There are moments when faith has to walk without the help of feelings.

The Dark Night of Faith

There is a difference between feeling God and trusting God.

When we feel comforted, it is relatively easy to say:

“God is with me.”

But what happens when we feel nothing?

That is when St. Augustine's words take on their full weight.

To believe in what we cannot yet see.

This is the logic of faith.

You do not need to see the other side of the road in order to take the next step.

You only need to trust the One who knows the way.

The desert is precisely where we learn to walk without a map.

And perhaps that is why it is so important.

As long as we have answers for everything, we trust in our own intelligence.

As long as we have resources for everything, we trust in our own abilities.

As long as we have people around us, we trust in their presence.

As long as we have health, money, opportunities, and security, it is easy to believe that we are in control.

Then the desert comes.

And it begins to dismantle those illusions.

Not to destroy you.

But to show you what truly sustains you.

“Never Despair of God’s Mercy”

The Rule of St. Benedict contains a simple and extraordinarily powerful phrase:

“Never despair of God’s mercy.”

It appears in Chapter 4 of the Rule, among the Instruments of Good Works.

Never.

No matter what has happened.

No matter how much time has passed.

No matter how many times you have fallen.

No matter how many times you have failed.

No matter how far away you believe you are.

Never lose hope.

Because God’s mercy does not depend on your ability to deserve it.

If it did, none of us would have hope.

Mercy exists precisely because we are incapable of saving ourselves.

Perhaps the greatest danger in the desert is not the pain.

It is reaching the conclusion that there is no way out.

That is when a man begins to say:

“What’s the point?”

“God doesn’t hear me.”

“My life is never going to change.”

“This is just who I am.”

“There is no hope anymore.”

The desert can try to convince you that the road has come to an end.

But the desert is not the destination.

It is a place you pass through.

When It Is All Over

Blessed Sebastian Valfré left a particularly striking statement about suffering:

“When all is over, you will not regret having suffered; rather, you will regret having suffered so little and suffered so badly.”

The saying is traditionally attributed to him and appears in sources of Catholic spirituality.

The first time we read it, it seems almost absurd.

Who would regret having suffered too little?

But perhaps the statement is not really about the amount of suffering.

It is about the way we suffer.

There is suffering that is wasted.

And there is suffering that is offered.

There is suffering that makes us bitter.

And there is suffering that makes us deeper.

There is suffering that closes us off.
And there is suffering that opens us up.
There is suffering that makes us hate God.
And there is suffering that makes us seek Him more sincerely.
Pain does not automatically determine the outcome.
We also have a part to play in that choice.
We can come out of hardship harder or wiser.
More bitter or more merciful.
More proud or more humble.
More distrustful or more trusting.
The same storm that breaks one tree can strengthen another.
It depends, in part, on where the roots are.

What the Desert Does to Us

Perhaps that is why some people, after going through great suffering, acquire a serenity they did not have before.
They have learned something that cannot be taught in books.
They have learned that everything passes.
They have learned that not every closed door is a tragedy.
They have learned that people can leave.
That plans can fail.
That money can disappear.
That health can fail.
That a reputation can be destroyed.

That the future can change in a single day.

And they have also learned that, even after all of that, it is still possible to get up in the morning.

It is still possible to pray.

It is still possible to love.

It is still possible to begin again.

This is a profound kind of freedom.

You stop demanding that life be exactly as you want it to be before you allow yourself to live.

You begin to accept that life is greater than your plans.

And you begin to understand that peace does not necessarily come from controlling your circumstances.

Sometimes it comes from surrendering to God what you cannot control.

Worry as a False Sense of Security

There is a kind of contradiction in excessive worry.

A person constantly thinks about what could go wrong because they believe that, if they think about it enough, they will somehow prevent it from happening.

But that is an illusion.

Thinking is not controlling.

Worrying is not preventing.

Anxiety about the future is not preparation for the future.

We can plan. We should be prudent. We should act responsibly.

But there comes a point when worry stops being prudence and becomes an attempt to take the place of Providence.

We want to know today what we will only be able to know tomorrow.

We want to guarantee today what may never even happen.

We want to control what belongs to the future.

And the future belongs to God.

This does not mean passivity.

It means doing what is within our power and entrusting to God what is beyond it.

There are things that depend on us.

There are things that do not depend on us.

Maturity means knowing the difference.

The Desert Ends

No desert lasts forever.

It may seem endless while we are in it.

But it ends.

The night ends.

The storm ends.

Winter ends.

Pain changes its shape.

The wound heals.

Life begins again.

And often, when we emerge from the desert, we realize that we are no longer the same person who entered it.

Perhaps we have lost some illusions.

But we have gained reality.

Perhaps we have lost some certainties.

But we have gained faith.

Perhaps we have lost some people.

But we have learned the value of presence.

Perhaps we have lost a certain sense of security.

But we have discovered Providence.

Perhaps we have lost control.

But we have found God.

And then we understand something that, at the beginning, would have been impossible to understand:

the desert was not empty.

We simply did not yet know how to recognize God's presence there.

God was in the silence.

He was in the waiting.

He was in the tears.

He was in the closed door.

He was in the humiliation.

He was in the fall.

He was there on that day when you thought you could not go on and, somehow, you kept going.

Perhaps you are still in your desert.

Perhaps you are tired.

Perhaps you cannot see a way out.

Perhaps you have been praying for months or years for something that still has not happened.

Then do not be too quick to abandon the path.

Do not confuse silence with abandonment.

Do not confuse waiting with being forgotten.

Do not confuse the desert with the end.

Keep going.

Pray.

Walk.

Do what is within your power.

And surrender to God what is not.

Because faith does not require you to see the whole road.

It only requires you to trust enough to take the next step.

And when you do not have the strength to take ten steps, take one.

When you cannot walk, stop and pray.

When you cannot pray, simply remain.

And when everything seems lost, remember the words of St. Benedict:

“Never despair of God’s mercy.”

The desert is not a promise that you will never suffer.

It is the discovery that you can pass through suffering without walking alone.

And perhaps, when you finally emerge from it, you will look back and understand:

God was not leading me into the desert to abandon me.

He was leading me there to teach me to depend on Him.